funeral, was not in the film. “I don’t like funerals,” he told Sergo Mikoyan later. “After all, it’s not like going to a wedding, right?” The young Mikoyan was shocked. Khrushchev’s backhanded compliment to his father’s diplomatic skills—“Only Anastas, with his oxlike perseverance, can withstand this. I would have put my foot down long ago and left!”—did nothing to alleviate the young man’s shock at what he considered Khrushchev’s cynicism. Anastas Mikoyan would never forgive Khrushchev his betrayal. For the time being, however, he remained in Havana and pushed as hard for the desired result as only he, with his “oxlike perseverance,” could do.[10]

Next day Mikoyan was ready to continue negotiations. His main goal was to overcome the mistrust between the two parties, and he began by explaining the reasons for placing the missiles in Cuba. The point, he argued, was not to create a military base there but to save Cuba from an American invasion. “When Khrushchev visited Bulgaria,” he began, sharing with the Cubans the official story about the origins of the idea, “he expressed many things to us; he said: ‘Although I was in Bulgaria, I was always thinking of Cuba. I fear the Yankees will attack Cuba, directly or indirectly, and imagine the effect on us of the defeat of the Cuban revolution. We cannot allow this to happen. Although the plan is very risky for us, it is a big responsibility, for it exposes us to a war. Cuba must be saved.” He also explained that Khrushchev did not have time to consult with Castro before sending his proposal to Kennedy: “Consultations would have been appropriate, but Cuba would not exist, and the world would be enveloped in a war.”[11]

The Cubans asked questions about guarantees of no American invasion, the Cuba-Turkey swap, and the existence of secret letters and agreements between Khrushchev and Kennedy. Mikoyan was prepared to share not only his recollections but also copies of Khrushchev’s letter to Kennedy. The Cubans still had their doubts and were more skeptical than trusting, but in Mikoyan’s opinion things were changing for the better. He decided to use that momentum at the meeting next day, November 5, to convince Castro to accept the inspection regime. With the Cubans adamantly opposed to any foreign inspection of their territory, Mikoyan came up with an ingenious proposal: to receive official American guarantees that they would not